

The Bet

Anton Chekhov · 1889

First published: tr. Constance Garnett, 1915–1920

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

AP edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Whole-book test and answer key
6. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Bet_and_Other_Stories/The_Bet (revision 7093575), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 8–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Bet suggest about the value of life?
- What does The Bet suggest about knowledge and renunciation?
- What does The Bet suggest about money and freedom?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: AP

AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN

AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the

app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Bet	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*the value of life* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Bet

Author biography

Anton Chekhov was born on 29 January 1860 in Taganrog, Russia, the grandson of a serf. He trained as a doctor in Moscow and supported his family by writing comic sketches for magazines, then turned to serious stories and plays; he called medicine his wife and literature his mistress. His plays The Seagull, Uncle Vanya, Three Sisters and The Cherry Orchard changed modern drama. He died of tuberculosis in Badenweiler, Germany, on 15 July 1904.

Historical and cultural context

In 1880s Russia, educated people debated the death penalty and life imprisonment; Russia also exiled prisoners to Siberia. Chekhov was a doctor and visited the prison island of Sakhalin in 1890.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in the newspaper Novoye Vremya (New Times) in 1889 under the title "A Tale"; Chekhov later shortened the ending and retitled it "The Bet."

Then: A minor work in its day.

Now: A classic for discussing values, freedom and the meaning of life.

Overview (spoiler-free)

At a party, a banker bets a young lawyer two million rubles that he cannot endure fifteen years of solitary confinement. The lawyer accepts and is locked in a garden lodge with books.

Main themes

- the value of life and freedom.
- greed.
- knowledge and wisdom.

Why it matters

It asks what really matters in a life, and whether knowledge leads to happiness.

Spoilers · teacher only

On the eve of his release, the ruined banker plans to kill him but finds a letter renouncing the money and all worldly things. The lawyer escapes five minutes early, losing the bet deliberately.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Bet: Would you spend fifteen years alone for two million dollars?
Prompt: Before we open The Bet: Would you spend fifteen years alone for two million dollars?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

frame narrative; character change; irony; flashback.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Anton Chekhov was born on 29 January 1860 in Taganrog, Russia, the grandson of a serf. He trained as a doctor in Moscow and supported his family by writing comic sketches for magazines, then turned to serious stories and plays; he called medicine his wife and literature his mistress. His plays The Seagull, Uncle Vanya, Three Sisters and The Cherry Orchard changed modern drama. He died of tuberculosis in Badenweiler, Germany, on 15 July 1904. The world of the book. In 1880s Russia, educated people debated the death penalty and life imprisonment; Russia also exiled prisoners to Siberia. Chekhov was a doctor and visited the prison island of Sakhalin in 1890. Publication and reception. First published in the newspaper Novoye Vremya (New Times) in 1889 under the title "A Tale"; Chekhov later shortened the ending and retitled it "The Bet." Then: A minor work in its day. Now: A classic for discussing values, freedom and the meaning of life.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

“I despise freedom, life, health, and all that your books call the blessings of the world” (The Bet, paragraph 34). The lawyer's letter.

> *I despise freedom, life, health, and all that your books call the blessings of the world (The Bet, paragraph 34)*

Think-aloud: “I despise freedom, life, health, and all that your books call the blessings of the world” (The Bet, paragraph 34). The lawyer's letter.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): At a party, a banker bets a young lawyer two million rubles that he cannot endure fifteen years of solitary confinement. The lawyer accepts and is locked in a garden lodge with books. Themes to track: the value of life and freedom.: greed.: knowledge and wisdom.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Bet: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Bet still matter? It asks what really matters in a life, and whether knowledge leads to happiness.
Anchor question: Why might The Bet still be taught today?
Facilitation: It asks what really matters in a life, and whether knowledge leads to happiness.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Who wins the bet? Answer: Technically the banker; morally, perhaps the lawyer, or neither.
Exit ticket: Who wins the bet?
Answer: Technically the banker; morally, perhaps the lawyer, or neither.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Bet.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Anton Chekhov" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Anton-Chekhov); Anton Chekhov, Stories (Constance Garnett translation) (https://www.gutenberg.org/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- The 1889 first publication in Novoye Vremya is well established; the original title "A Tale" and the extent of the later revision should be checked against a scholarly edition. Translations differ in details.

Lesson 2: The Bet

Focus: what fifteen years of solitude teach

Content note (contemplated murder): Sensitive content: Contemplated murder. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes contemplated murder.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

At a party a banker bets a young lawyer two million rubles that he cannot stay fifteen years in solitary confinement. The lawyer reads everything, from stories to languages and theology. On the eve of the end the ruined banker plans to kill him, but finds a letter renouncing the money and all worldly goods as vanity. The lawyer escapes five hours early, forfeiting; the banker locks the letter in his safe.

Background: Written 1889. Translation used: S. Koteliansky and J. M. Murry, The Bet and Other Stories (1915), public domain in the US.

Significance: Raises the capital punishment versus life imprisonment debate and the meaning of knowledge; on Glencoe grade 9 lesson plans.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is it better to die than to spend life in prison? Why? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to the value of life and freedom because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes contemplated murder.
Prompt: Is it better to die than to spend life in prison? Why?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to the value of life and freedom because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the lawyer comes to despise everything people value.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: unwearying — never tiring; emaciation — extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food; bartered — traded goods or things of value instead of using money; erudite — having or showing great learning; zealously — in a zealous manner.
Words: unwearying: never tiring · emaciation: extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food · bartered: traded goods or things of value instead of using money · erudite: having or showing great learning · zealously: in a zealous manner

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Written 1889. Translation used: S. Koteliansky and J. M. Murry, The Bet and Other Stories (1915), public domain in the US. Raises the capital punishment versus life imprisonment debate and the meaning of knowledge; on Glencoe grade 9 lesson plans. Structure: A frame: the banker remembers the bet on the night before it ends. Characterization: The banker grows from reckless to desperate; the lawyer changes through reading, from impulse to renunciation. Irony: The lawyer gives up the very money that would save the banker from murder. Watch for the books: the stages of the lawyer's inner journey.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "I despise freedom, life, health" (The Bet, paragraph 34). The letter. That is structure at work: A frame: the banker remembers the bet on the night before it ends.

> *I despise freedom, life, health (The Bet, paragraph 34)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "I despise freedom, life, health" (The Bet, paragraph 34). The letter. That is structure at work: A frame: the banker remembers the bet on the night before it ends.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Comparing life to a mirage suggests that worldly goods are illusions. Ask: How does this line connect to the value of life and freedom? Expected: The lawyer comes to despise everything people value. (The lawyer's conclusion.)

> *Everything is void, frail, visionary and delusive like a mirage (The Bet, paragraph 37)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Comparing life to a mirage suggests that worldly goods are illusions.
Ask: How does this line connect to the value of life and freedom?
Expected answer: The lawyer comes to despise everything people value. (The lawyer's conclusion.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about what fifteen years of solitude teach? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Bet develops the idea of what fifteen years of solitude teach. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim. Read in the public-domain translation by S. S. Koteliansky and J. M. Murry.) Exemplar: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. When the text says “Everything is void, frail, visionary and delusive like a mirage” (The Bet, paragraph 37), it shows this directly. The banker begins by saying "Two millions are nothing to me" and ends ruined and ready to kill, while the lawyer concludes that "Everything is void, frail, visionary and delusive like a mirage" and gives up the money.
Task: Annotate the story for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about what fifteen years of solitude teach? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Bet develops the idea of what fifteen years of solitude teach. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim. Read in the public-domain translation by S. S. Koteliansky and J. M. Murry.)
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70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is it better to die than to spend life in prison? Why? Ask: is the lawyer wise, or broken?
Anchor question: Is it better to die than to spend life in prison? Why?
Facilitation: Ask: is the lawyer wise, or broken?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about what fifteen years of solitude teach? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. (“Everything is void, frail, visionary and delusive like a mirage”, The Bet, paragraph 37). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about what fifteen years of solitude teach? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. (“Everything is void, frail, visionary and delusive like a mirage”, The Bet, paragraph 37). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how structure shapes what fifteen years of solitude teach. Key takeaway: the lawyer comes to despise everything people value.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Structure:** A frame: the banker remembers the bet on the night before it ends.
- **Characterization:** The banker grows from reckless to desperate; the lawyer changes through reading, from impulse to renunciation.
- **Irony:** The lawyer gives up the very money that would save the banker from murder.

Themes and how they develop

- **the value of life and freedom:** the lawyer comes to despise everything people value.

Symbols and motifs

- **the books:** the stages of the lawyer's inner journey.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "I despise freedom, life, health" (The Bet, paragraph 34) The letter.
- "Two millions are nothing to me" (The Bet, paragraph 12) The banker's arrogance.
- "Everything is void, frail, visionary and delusive like a mirage" (The Bet, paragraph 37) The lawyer's conclusion.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it.
Evidence: "Everything is void, frail, visionary and delusive like a mirage" (The Bet, paragraph 37)
Reasoning: The banker begins by saying "Two millions are nothing to me" and ends ruined and ready to kill, while the lawyer concludes that "Everything is void, frail, visionary and delusive like a mirage" and gives up the money.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
unwearying (adjective)	never tiring	*All that unwearying human thought created in the centuries is compressed to a little lump in my skull.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

emaciation (noun)	extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food	*His hair was already silvering with grey, and no one who glanced at the senile emaciation of the face would have believed that he was only forty years old.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
bartered (verb)	traded goods or things of value instead of using money	*So do I marvel at you, who have bartered heaven for earth.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
erudite (adjective)	having or showing great learning	*The banker found it strange that a man who in four years had mastered six hundred erudite volumes, should have spent nearly a year in reading one book, easy to understand and by no means thick.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
zealously (adverb)	in a zealous manner	*In the second half of the sixth year, the prisoner began zealously to study languages, philosophy, and history.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
caprice (noun)	a tendency to change one's mind suddenly	*On my part, it was the caprice of a well-fed man; on the lawyer's, pure greed of gold."*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
communicate (verb)	transmit information	*By the agreement he could communicate, but only in silence, with the outside world through a little window specially constructed for this purpose.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
visited (verb)	called on (someone)	*And beautiful women, like clouds ethereal, created by the magic of your poets' genius, visited me by night and whispered me wonderful tales, which made my head drunken.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Is it better to die than to spend life in prison? Why?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with the value of life?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What starts the bet? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: An argument about capital punishment versus life imprisonment
2. How long must the lawyer stay confined? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Fifteen years

3. What is the prize? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Two million rubles
4. Why does the banker plan to kill the lawyer? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Paying would ruin him
5. What does the lawyer do at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: Renounces the money and leaves early
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Bet" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: At a party a banker bets a young lawyer two million rubles that he cannot stay fifteen years in solitary confinement. The lawyer reads everything, from stories to languages and theology. On the eve of the end the ruined banker plans to kill him, but finds a letter renouncing the money and all worldly goods as vanity. The lawyer escapes five hours early, forfeiting; the banker locks the letter in…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Bet"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Bet" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "All that unwearying human thought created in the centuries is compressed to a little lump in my skull." What does "unwearying" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: unwearying: never tiring.
10. Reread: "His hair was already silvering with grey, and no one who glanced at the senile emaciation of the face would have believed that he was only forty years old." What does "emaciation" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: emaciation: extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Bet" suggest about what fifteen years of solitude teach? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: Raises the capital punishment versus life imprisonment debate and the meaning of knowledge; on Glencoe grade 9 lesson plans.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the structure in this story shape what we understand about what fifteen years of solitude teach? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Look for how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: "I despise freedom, life, health" (The Bet, paragraph 34): The letter. On structure: A frame: the banker remembers the bet on the night before it ends. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins ""Why did I make this bet?", why might Chekhov have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in "The Bet", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: At a party a banker bets a young lawyer two million rubles that he cannot stay

fifteen years in solitary confinement. The lawyer reads everything, from stories to languages and theology. On the eve of the end the ruined banker plans to kill him, but finds a letter renouncing the money and all…

6. As the opening story, what does "The Bet" set up that the rest of The Bet will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: "Two millions are nothing to me" (The Bet, paragraph 12): The banker's arrogance. On structure: A frame: the banker remembers the bet on the night before it ends. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: "Everything is void, frail, visionary and delusive like a mirage" (The Bet, paragraph 37): The lawyer's conclusion. On characterization: The banker grows from reckless to desperate; the lawyer changes through reading, from impulse to renunciation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: "Is it better to die than to spend life in prison? Why?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with the value of life? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: "I despise freedom, life, health" (The Bet, paragraph 34): The letter. On characterization: The banker grows from reckless to desperate; the lawyer changes through reading, from impulse to renunciation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Written 1889. Translation used: S. Koteliansky and J. M. Murry, The Bet and Other Stories (1915), public domain in the US. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: "Two millions are nothing to me" (The Bet, paragraph 12): The banker's arrogance. Theme link: the lawyer comes to despise everything people value. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "Raises the capital punishment versus life imprisonment debate and the meaning of knowledge; on Glencoe grade 9 lesson plans." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: "Everything is void, frail, visionary and delusive like a mirage" (The Bet, paragraph 37): The lawyer's conclusion. Theme link: the lawyer comes to despise everything people value.

Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: “I despise freedom, life, health” (The Bet, paragraph 34): The letter. On characterization: The banker grows from reckless to desperate; the lawyer changes through reading, from impulse to renunciation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Bet” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about what fifteen years of solitude teach? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: “Two millions are nothing to me” (The Bet, paragraph 12): The banker's arrogance. Theme link: the lawyer comes to despise everything people value. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Bet”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: “Everything is void, frail, visionary and delusive like a mirage” (The Bet, paragraph 37): The lawyer's conclusion. Theme link: the lawyer comes to despise everything people value. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to knowledge and renunciation: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Chekhov need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: “I despise freedom, life, health” (The Bet, paragraph 34): The letter. Theme link: the lawyer comes to despise everything people value. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: “Two millions are nothing to me” (The Bet, paragraph 12): The banker's arrogance. On irony: The lawyer gives up the very money that would save the banker from murder. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Compare how “The Bet” treats what fifteen years of solitude teach with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Bet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: “Everything is void, frail, visionary and delusive like a mirage” (The Bet,

paragraph 37): The lawyer's conclusion. Theme link: the lawyer comes to despise everything people value. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve the value of life? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: “I despise freedom, life, health” (The Bet, paragraph 34): The letter. Theme link: the lawyer comes to despise everything people value. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about what fifteen years of solitude teach? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: “Two millions are nothing to me” (The Bet, paragraph 12): The banker's arrogance. Theme link: the lawyer comes to despise everything people value. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Anton Chekhov about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Both men are changed by the bet, but only the lawyer learns from it. Useful evidence: “Everything is void, frail, visionary and delusive like a mirage” (The Bet, paragraph 37): The lawyer's conclusion. Theme link: the lawyer comes to despise everything people value. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Structure**: how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz

1. What starts the bet?
   A. A business deal
   B. An argument about capital punishment versus life imprisonment
   C. A card game
   D. A dare about fasting
2. How long must the lawyer stay confined?
   A. Ten years
   B. Fifteen years
   C. Five years
   D. Twenty years

3. What is the prize?
   A. Two million rubles
   B. A house
   C. A marriage
   D. A pardon
4. Why does the banker plan to kill the lawyer?
   A. The lawyer escaped
   B. Paying would ruin him
   C. Revenge
   D. Jealousy
5. What does the lawyer do at the end?
   A. Stays longer
   B. Dies
   C. Claims the money
   D. Renounces the money and leaves early
6. In the line "All that unwearying human thought created in the centuries is compressed to a little lump in my skull.", what does "unwearying" most nearly mean?
   A. extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food
   B. never tiring
   C. traded goods or things of value instead of using money
   D. having or showing great learning
7. In the line "His hair was already silvering with grey, and no one who glanced at the senile emaciation of the face would have believed that he was only forty years old.", what does "emaciation" most nearly mean?
   A. having or showing great learning
   B. extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food
   C. never tiring
   D. traded goods or things of value instead of using money

Answer key: 1. B (An argument about capital punishment versus life imprisonment); 2. B (Fifteen years); 3. A (Two million rubles); 4. B (Paying would ruin him); 5. D (Renounces the money and leaves early); 6. B (never tiring); 7. B (extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "The Bet," how does Chekhov show what fifteen years of solitude teach? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; AP: see unit standards): In The Bet, how does Chekhov develop the idea of what fifteen years of solitude teach? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the

irony in the story helps build that idea. Read in the public-domain translation by S. S. Koteliansky and J. M. Murry.

HS Sophomore (450 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how The Bet develops the idea of what fifteen years of solitude teach. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim. Read in the public-domain translation by S. S. Koteliansky and J. M. Murry.

HS Junior (550 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how the structure of The Bet (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of what fifteen years of solitude teach. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Two readers disagree about what The Bet suggests about what fifteen years of solitude teach. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and structure), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Anton Chekhov uses irony in The Bet to complicate the reader's understanding of what fifteen years of solitude teach. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Situate The Bet within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of what fifteen years of solitude teach responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; AP: see unit standards): Read The Bet alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of what fifteen years of solitude teach follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; AP: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Bet and its treatment of what fifteen years of solitude teach. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and structure, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Bet as evidence for a larger claim about what fifteen years of solitude teach in The Bet. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Bet as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of what fifteen years of solitude teach. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial

approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Bet.

SAT-style questions

1. *So do I marvel at you, who have bartered heaven for earth.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "bartered" most nearly mean?

   A. a tendency to change one's mind suddenly

   B. traded goods or things of value instead of using money

   C. called on (someone)

   D. transmit information

2. *"Why did I make this bet? What's the good? The lawyer loses fifteen years of his life and I throw away two millions. Will it convince people that capital punishment is worse or better than imprisonment for life. No, No! All stuff and rubbish. On my part, it was the caprice of a well-fed man; on the lawyer's, pure greed of gold."*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "The Bet"?

   A. Greed that grasps more than a person needs

   B. A story so convincing it becomes real

   C. What fifteen years of solitude teach

   D. Confinement driving a woman into madness

SAT key: 1. B (traded goods or things of value instead of using money); 2. C (What fifteen years of solitude teach)

Whole-book test

The Bet: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What starts the bet?
   A. A business deal
   B. An argument about capital punishment versus life imprisonment
   C. A card game
   D. A dare about fasting
2. How long must the lawyer stay confined?
   A. Ten years
   B. Fifteen years
   C. Five years
   D. Twenty years
3. What is the prize?
   A. Two million rubles
   B. A house
   C. A marriage
   D. A pardon
4. Why does the banker plan to kill the lawyer?
   A. The lawyer escaped
   B. Paying would ruin him
   C. Revenge
   D. Jealousy
5. What does the lawyer do at the end?
   A. Stays longer
   B. Dies
   C. Claims the money
   D. Renounces the money and leaves early
6. In the line “All that unwearying human thought created in the centuries is compressed to a little lump in my skull.”, what does “unwearying” most nearly mean?
   A. extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food
   B. never tiring
   C. traded goods or things of value instead of using money
   D. having or showing great learning

7. In the line “His hair was already silvering with grey, and no one who glanced at the senile emaciation of the face would have believed that he was only forty years old.”, what does “emaciation” most nearly mean?
   A. having or showing great learning
   B. extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food
   C. never tiring
   D. traded goods or things of value instead of using money
8. As used in the story (“All that unwearying human thought created in the centuries is compressed to a little lump in my skull.”), what does “unwearying” mean?
   A. never tiring
   B. in a zealous manner
   C. called on (someone)
   D. having or showing great learning
9. As used in the story (“His hair was already silvering with grey, and no one who glanced at the senile emaciation of the face would have believed that he was only f”), what does “emaciation” mean?
   A. a tendency to change one's mind suddenly
   B. extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food
   C. never tiring
   D. in a zealous manner
10. As used in the story (“So do I marvel at you, who have bartered heaven for earth.”), what does “bartered” mean?
    A. transmit information
    B. extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food
    C. traded goods or things of value instead of using money
    D. a tendency to change one's mind suddenly
11. As used in the story (“The banker found it strange that a man who in four years had mastered six hundred erudite volumes, should have spent nearly a year in readin”), what does “erudite” mean?
    A. called on (someone)
    B. traded goods or things of value instead of using money
    C. transmit information
    D. having or showing great learning
12. As used in the story (“In the second half of the sixth year, the prisoner began zealously to study languages, philosophy, and history.”), what does “zealously” mean?
    A. in a zealous manner
    B. never tiring
    C. having or showing great learning
    D. called on (someone)

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how the value of life develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how knowledge and renunciation develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how money and freedom develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (the value of life, knowledge and renunciation, money and freedom) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. B (An argument about capital punishment versus life imprisonment); 2. B (Fifteen years); 3. A (Two million rubles); 4. B (Paying would ruin him); 5. D (Renounces the money and leaves early); 6. B (never tiring); 7. B (extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food); 8. A (never tiring); 9. B (extreme thinness caused by illness or lack of food); 10. C (traded goods or things of value instead of using money); 11. D (having or showing great learning); 12. A (in a zealous manner)

Essay assignments

Essay: The value of life

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Bet teaches about the value of life. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Anton Chekhov develops the value of life in The Bet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Anton Chekhov develops the value of life across The Bet. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Bet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the value of life. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the value of life in The Bet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Anton Chekhov's choices in The Bet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the value of life, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Bet's treatment of the value of life in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the value of life in The Bet that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the value of life in The Bet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the value of life in The Bet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the value of life in The Bet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Knowledge and renunciation

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Bet teaches about knowledge and renunciation. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Anton Chekhov develops knowledge and renunciation in The Bet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Anton Chekhov develops knowledge and renunciation across The Bet. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Bet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of knowledge and renunciation. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of knowledge and renunciation in The Bet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Anton Chekhov's choices in The Bet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of knowledge and renunciation, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Bet's treatment of knowledge and renunciation in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on knowledge and renunciation in The Bet that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on knowledge and renunciation in The Bet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about knowledge and renunciation in The Bet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on knowledge and renunciation in The Bet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Money and freedom

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Bet teaches about money and freedom. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Anton Chekhov develops money and freedom in The Bet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Anton Chekhov develops money and freedom across The Bet. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Bet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of money and freedom. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of money and freedom in The Bet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Anton Chekhov's choices in The Bet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of money and freedom, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Bet's treatment of money and freedom in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on money and freedom in The Bet that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on money and freedom in The Bet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about money and freedom in The Bet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on money and freedom in The Bet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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